I asked if I could try.

Everyone guffawed. *Sod off!*

Willy looked at me in horror.

But I wouldn't back off. I pleaded my case. I was *experienced*, I said.

Heads swung round. *Oh really?*

Henners and I had recently pinched two six-packs of Smirnoff Ice and drunk them till we passed out, I boasted. Plus, Tiggy always let me have a nip of her flask on stalking trips. (Sloe gin, she was never without it.) I thought it best to leave out the full breadth of my experience.

The adults exchanged sly glances. One shrugged, rolled a new joint, passed it to me.

I took a puff. Coughed, retched. African weed was much harsher than Eton weed. And the high was less too.

But at least I was a man.

No. I was still a wee baby.

The "joint" was just fresh basil wrapped in a bit of filthy rolling paper.

25.

HUGH AND EMILIE were old friends of Pa's. They lived in Norfolk, and we often went to visit them for a week or two, during school holidays and summers. They had four sons with whom Willy and I were always thrown together, like pups into a bunch of pit bulls.

We played games. One day Hide and Seek, the next Capture the Flag. But whatever the game it was always an excuse for a massive scrap, and whatever the scrap, there were no winners because there were no rules. Hair-pulling, eye-gouging, arm-twisting, sleeper holds, all was fair in love and war and at Hugh and Emilie's country house.

As the youngest and smallest I always took the brunt. But I also did the most escalating, the most asking for it, so I deserved everything I got. Black eye, violet welt, puffed lip, I didn't mind. On the contrary. Maybe I wanted to look tough. Maybe I just wanted to feel *something*. Whatever my motivation, my simple philosophy when it came to scrapping was: More, please.